
LOOPIFY

Complete Costing & Provider Comparison

WhatsApp API Providers | Database Options | Hosting | Final Recommendation

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1. Why This Document

We are launching Loopify as a SaaS product — a tiffin service CRM that any tiffin business can purchase and use. Before we finalise the stack, I wanted to do a proper comparison of all the WhatsApp API providers available to us, and also look at whether we should stick with SQLite or move to a managed database like Supabase, Firebase, or MongoDB.

Two companies have reached out to us directly — 11ZA (they sent a formal quote) and EaseByAI (they contacted us on WhatsApp). I have also evaluated Twilio (which our CRM already supports) and the option of integrating directly with Meta's Cloud API without any middleman.

This document covers everything: what each provider does, how much it costs, who gives demos, what the risks are, and what I think we should go with.

2. WhatsApp API Providers — Full Comparison

First, some context. WhatsApp does not let you just send messages from your own server. You have to go through their Cloud API, and there are two ways to do it:

Option A — Direct Integration: You connect directly to Meta's Cloud API. No middleman. You pay only Meta's per-message rates. But you have to build everything yourself — webhook handling, template management, message queuing, retry logic, analytics.

Option B — Through a BSP (Business Solution Provider): Companies like Twilio, 11ZA, and EaseByAI sit between you and Meta. They give you a dashboard, chatbot builder, broadcast tools, analytics, etc. You pay Meta's rates PLUS the BSP's platform fee and markup.

2.1 Direct Meta Cloud API

This is the cheapest option in terms of per-message cost because there is no middleman. Meta hosts the API on their servers (they shut down the on-premise option in Oct 2025). You get a free WhatsApp Business Account, connect your number, and start sending messages.

How it works for Loopify:

Our CRM already has webhook endpoints built for Meta's format (check backend/routes/whatsapp.js). So technically, we can connect directly to Meta without any BSP. We would need to manage template approvals through Meta Business Manager ourselves, and build our own broadcast/bulk-send logic.

Item	Cost	Notes
Platform / Setup Fee	FREE	No license fee from Meta
Marketing Message	Rs 0.8631 / msg	Promos, new menu alerts, offers
Utility Message	Rs 0.115 / msg	Order confirm, delivery updates
Authentication	Rs 0.115 / msg	OTP verification
Service (user-initiated)	FREE	Customer replies in 24hr window
Dashboard / Chatbot	N/A — build yourself	Need engineering effort (2-6 weeks)
Demo Available?	No	Self-service — just sign up on business.facebook.com

Pros: Cheapest per-message. No vendor lock-in. Our CRM already supports Meta webhook format.

Cons: No ready-made dashboard for non-tech team. Template management is manual. No chatbot builder included. Need developer time to set up.

2.2 Twilio

Twilio is what our CRM currently supports for outbound messages (check the TWILIO_SID, TWILIO_TOKEN env vars). It is a developer-friendly API — you send messages via REST calls, they handle delivery. No fancy dashboard or chatbot builder, but very reliable and well-documented.

Item	Cost	Notes
Platform Fee	FREE (pay-per-use)	No monthly subscription
Twilio Markup	Rs 0.42 / msg (\$0.005)	On top of Meta's rates, both inbound & outbound
Marketing Message (total)	Rs 1.28 / msg	Meta Rs 0.86 + Twilio Rs 0.42
Utility Message (total)	Rs 0.535 / msg	Meta Rs 0.115 + Twilio Rs 0.42

Item	Cost	Notes
Service (total)	Rs 0.42 / msg	Meta free + Twilio Rs 0.42
Dashboard / Chatbot	N/A — API only	Developer tool. No visual dashboard.
Demo / Trial	Free trial credits	\$15 free credit on signup. Test sandbox available.

Pros: Already integrated in our CRM. Pay-per-use (no monthly fee). Free trial with \$15 credit. Very reliable. Great docs.

Cons: Per-message markup adds up. No chatbot/broadcast UI. Service messages also charged (Rs 0.42). Developer-only tool.

2.3 11ZA (Indian BSP — Quoted to Us)

11ZA sent us a formal quote. They are an Indian WhatsApp BSP that provides a dashboard with Broadcast, Chatbot builder, and Custom Integrations. Their pricing is subscription-based with a message wallet system.

Item	Cost	Notes
Half-Yearly Plan	Rs 10,000 / 6 months	Includes 2,500 message balance
Yearly Plan	Rs 15,000 / year	Includes 3,000 message balance
Custom Integration	Rs 50,000 (one-time)	For custom requirements
Marketing Message	Rs 0.83 / msg	Slightly lower than direct Meta (Oct 2024 rate)
Utility / Auth	Rs 0.15 / msg	Comparable to Meta's rates
Service (user-initiated)	FREE	Same as Meta policy
Facebook Verification	Rs 0 - 5,000	Free if already verified. Rs 3K with website, Rs 5K without.
Blue Tick (optional)	Rs 0 - 75,000	Free if PR links available. Rs 75K if applying from scratch.
Extra Users (beyond 10)	Rs 2,000 / user / year	Plan includes up to 10 users
Dashboard / Chatbot	INCLUDED	Broadcast, chatbot builder, integrations
Demo Available?	Not mentioned in quote	Need to ask. They are based in India.

Pros: Full dashboard with chatbot + broadcast. Indian company (Hindi support likely). Yearly plan is reasonable. 10 users included.

Cons: Subscription fee ON TOP of per-message costs. Rs 50K for custom integration is steep. No refund policy. Number cannot be changed once activated. Meta account restriction risk (they warned about this).

Important Warning from 11ZA's Quote:

They have flagged that new Business Managers and WhatsApp numbers are seeing higher risk of restriction by Meta — sometimes even before a single message is sent. If restricted, there is a 48-hour window to raise a review, and reactivation can take 30-60 days. They recommend using a test number for the first 5-10 days.

2.4 EaseByAI (Indian BSP — Contacted Us on WhatsApp)

EaseByAI reached out to us on WhatsApp offering their WhatsApp automation platform. They are based in Surat and claim 50,000+ businesses on their platform. Their website is easebyai.in (redirects to easebyai.com). They offer WhatsApp + Instagram automation with AI chatbot capabilities.

Unfortunately, their pricing is not publicly available on their website — the site is fully client-rendered and does not show plan details without signing up. Based on their WhatsApp message to us, they directed us to Meta's pricing page and offered a quick demo.

Item	Cost	Notes
Platform Fee	Not publicly listed	Need to request quote. Website does not show pricing.
Message Rates	Meta rates (pass-through)	They pointed us to Meta's pricing page directly
Features	WhatsApp + Instagram AI Automation	AI chatbot, broadcast, custom integrations

Item	Cost	Notes
Users	50,000+ businesses (claimed)	Surat-based company
Setup	2 minutes, no coding	As per their website tagline
Demo Available?	YES — offered on WhatsApp	They said 'reply for a quick demo'

Pros: Offered demo proactively. AI-powered chatbot (could save manual effort). Instagram automation bonus. No-code setup claimed.

Cons: Pricing not transparent — you have to ask. Cannot evaluate cost without their quote. Relatively unknown company (not in major comparison lists). No public reviews found.

2.5 WhatsApp Provider — Side-by-Side Comparison

Feature	Direct Meta	Twilio	11ZA	EaseByAI
Monthly Platform Fee	FREE	FREE	Rs 1,250/mo (yearly plan)	Not public (ask)
Marketing / msg	Rs 0.86	Rs 1.28	Rs 0.83	Rs 0.86 (Meta pass-through?)
Utility / msg	Rs 0.115	Rs 0.535	Rs 0.15	Rs 0.115 (Meta?)
Service / msg	FREE	Rs 0.42	FREE	FREE (?)
Dashboard	No (DIY)	No (API only)	Yes (included)	Yes (AI-powered)
Chatbot Builder	No	No	Yes	Yes (AI)
Broadcast	Build yourself	Build yourself	Included	Included
Free Trial / Demo	Self-service	\$15 free credit	Not mentioned	Yes (demo offered)
Setup Effort	2-6 weeks dev	Already done	Managed by them	2 mins (claimed)
Lock-in Risk	None	Low	Number locked	Unknown
Refund Policy	N/A	N/A	No refunds	Unknown
100 cust/mo cost*	Rs 1,500 - 4,300	Rs 2,100 - 5,500	Rs 2,750 - 5,550	Unknown + platform

* 100 customer monthly cost estimated with normal usage (2 utility/day + 2 marketing/week). Platform fees added for subscription-based providers.

My Verdict on WhatsApp Providers:

For Loopify at our stage (100 customers, low budget, already have a working CRM), I think the best approach is to **stick with Twilio for now**. Here is why — our CRM already supports it, there is no monthly fee (pay-per-use only), and we get \$15 free credit to test. The per-message markup (Rs 0.42) is the cost of not having to build everything from scratch.

If we grow beyond 500 customers and the Twilio markup becomes significant, we should switch to **Direct Meta Cloud API** — our webhook code already handles Meta's format, so the migration would be straightforward. The only work would be building a template management UI and broadcast feature.

I would hold off on 11ZA and EaseByAI for now. 11ZA's no-refund policy and number-lock are risky, and their Rs 50K custom integration fee is too much for our stage. EaseByAI's lack of transparent pricing is a concern — we should ask for their quote and demo before deciding, but not commit yet.

3. Database Options — Full Comparison

Right now Loopify uses SQLite through the better-sqlite3 library. The database is a single file (dabbabox.db) that sits on the same server. The question is: should we move to a managed database service? Let me compare all the options.

3.1 SQLite (Current — What We Use)

SQLite is an embedded database — it runs inside our Node.js process, reads and writes to a single file. There is no separate database server, no connection string, no network calls. It is incredibly fast for our use case.

Aspect	Rating	Details
Cost	Rs 0 / month	Free forever. Open source. Included with the server.
Performance	Excellent	Synchronous queries, no network latency. WAL mode enabled.
Scalability Limit	~500 concurrent users	Single-server only. Cannot scale horizontally.
Backup	Built into our CRM	JSON export + CSV export + file copy. All free.
Multi-server	Not possible	Cannot run 2 servers pointing to same SQLite file.
SaaS Multi-tenant	Works (1 DB per tenant)	Each tiffin business gets their own DB file.

3.2 Supabase (PostgreSQL — Managed)

Supabase is like Firebase but built on PostgreSQL. It gives you a full database + auth + file storage + realtime subscriptions — all in one. It is open source and has a generous free tier.

Aspect	Rating / Cost	Details
Free Tier	500 MB DB, 50K MAU	2 free projects. Pauses after 1 week of inactivity.
Pro Plan	Rs 2,080/mo (\$25)	8 GB DB, 100K MAU, 100 GB storage, no pause.
Team Plan	Rs 49,900/mo (\$599)	SOC2 compliance, 14-day backups. Way too much for us.
Auth / Users	Built-in	Email, phone, social login. Replaces our JWT code.
Realtime	Built-in	Live data sync — useful for Android app.
File Storage	1 GB free, scalable	Good for product images, invoices.
Migration Effort	Medium (1-2 weeks)	Need to rewrite DB layer from SQLite to PostgreSQL.

3.3 Firebase (Firestore — Google)

Firebase is Google's app platform. Firestore is their NoSQL database. It is popular for mobile apps because of its realtime sync and offline support. However, it uses a completely different data model (documents/collections instead of SQL tables).

Aspect	Rating / Cost	Details
Free (Spark)	50K reads/day, 20K writes	1 GB storage. No Cloud Storage since Feb 2026.
Blaze (Pay-as-go)	\$0.18 / 100K reads	Unpredictable costs. Heavy reads = expensive bills.

Aspect	Rating / Cost	Details
Auth	Built-in (10K/mo free)	Very good for mobile apps. Google/Phone login.
Realtime Sync	Excellent for mobile	Best-in-class offline support for Android.
SQL Queries	Not supported	NoSQL only. Cannot do JOINS. Major rewrite needed.
Migration Effort	HIGH (3-4 weeks)	Complete rewrite — different data model entirely.
Cost Predictability	POOR	Pay-per-read. Dashboard page loading = reads = charges.

3.4 MongoDB Atlas (NoSQL — Managed)

MongoDB is a document database (JSON-like). It is flexible and popular, but like Firebase, it is NoSQL — which means our entire SQL-based backend would need rewriting.

Aspect	Rating / Cost	Details
Free (M0)	512 MB RAM, 5 GB storage	Shared cluster. Free forever. Good for testing.
Flex Tier	Rs 665 - 2,500/mo (\$8-30)	100-500 ops/sec. Good middle ground.
Dedicated (M10)	Rs 4,830/mo (~\$58)	2 GB RAM, 10 GB NVMe. Real production use.
SQL Queries	Not native SQL	MongoDB Query Language. Our SQL queries need rewriting.
Migration Effort	HIGH (3-4 weeks)	Different data model. All SQL queries need rewriting.
Scaling	Excellent	Horizontal scaling, sharding, replication.

3.5 Database — Side-by-Side Comparison

Feature	SQLite	Supabase	Firebase	MongoDB
Monthly Cost (100 cust)	Rs 0	Rs 0 (free) or Rs 2,080	Rs 0 (Spark) or variable	Rs 0 (M0) or Rs 665+
Data Model	SQL (relational)	SQL (PostgreSQL)	NoSQL (documents)	NoSQL (documents)
Migration from current	None needed	Medium (1-2 wks)	Major rewrite	Major rewrite
Auth built-in	No (we built JWT)	Yes	Yes	No (Atlas App Svc)
Realtime sync	No	Yes	Yes (best)	Change streams
Android-friendly	Via our API	Via API + SDK	Excellent SDK	Realm SDK
Multi-tenant SaaS	1 DB per tenant	Schemas/RLS	Security rules	Per-tenant DB
Best for Loopify?	NOW (100 cust)	FUTURE (500+)	If mobile-first	If scaling big

My Verdict on Databases:

Stay with SQLite for now. At 100 customers, it costs us nothing, it is already working, and there is zero migration effort. Our CRM uses SQL throughout — moving to Firebase or MongoDB would mean rewriting every single database query in the backend.

When we are ready to scale (500+ customers, multiple tiffin businesses as SaaS clients), **Supabase is the natural upgrade path.** It uses PostgreSQL which is SQL-compatible — our existing queries will mostly work with minor changes. It also gives us built-in auth, realtime sync (great for Hussain's Android app), and file storage. The free tier (500 MB) is enough to start, and Pro at Rs 2,080/month is very reasonable.

Firebase would only make sense if we were building a mobile-first app from scratch (which we are not — we already have a web CRM). MongoDB is powerful but overkill for our use case and would require a complete rewrite.

4. Hosting & Other Infrastructure

Covering this briefly since the previous version of this document had the details. Here is the summary:

Service	Monthly Cost	Notes
Hetzner CX22	Rs 300/mo	2 vCPU, 4GB RAM. Best value.
DigitalOcean Basic	Rs 500/mo	1 vCPU, 1GB RAM. Good enough for 100 customers.
Render Starter	Rs 580/mo	Managed Node.js. Easy deploy but cold starts.
Domain (.in)	Rs 60-75/mo	Rs 700-900/year
SSL (Let's Encrypt)	FREE	Auto-renewing with nginx/certbot
Backup Storage	Rs 100/mo	S3-compatible cloud storage for nightly DB copy

5. Total Monthly Cost — All Scenarios

Scenario	Monthly Cost (100 cust)	Notes
A. Minimum Budget		
Hetzner + Direct Meta + SQLite	Rs 1,800 - 4,600	Cheapest possible. Need dev time for Meta API.
B. Recommended (Our Pick)		
DigitalOcean + Twilio + SQLite	Rs 2,700 - 6,200	Already working. No migration needed. Best ROI.
C. With 11ZA		
DigitalOcean + 11ZA + SQLite	Rs 3,350 - 6,600	Adds Rs 1,250/mo platform fee. Dashboard included.
D. Future Scale (500+ customers)		
DO + Direct Meta + Supabase Pro	Rs 5,000 - 10,000	When we outgrow SQLite + Twilio markup.

RECOMMENDED FOR NOW: DigitalOcean (Rs 500) + Twilio (Rs 2,100-4,300) + SQLite (Rs 0) + Domain+SSL (Rs 75) + Backup (Rs 100)
= Rs 2,775 to Rs 4,975 per month for 100 customers
That is Rs 28 to Rs 50 per customer per month.

6. Final Recommendation for Loopify

Here is what I think we should do, broken into immediate and future steps:

Right Now (0-6 months, 100 customers):

1. Keep Twilio as our WhatsApp provider — it is already integrated, no monthly fee, and we get free trial credits.
2. Keep SQLite as our database — it costs nothing and handles 100 customers without breaking a sweat.
3. Deploy on DigitalOcean or Hetzner — Rs 300-500/month is very affordable.
4. Use Let's Encrypt for SSL (free) and a .in domain (Rs 700/year).
5. Total cost: approximately Rs 2,800-5,000/month depending on WhatsApp message volume.

Growth Phase (6-18 months, 500+ customers):

1. Switch from Twilio to Direct Meta Cloud API — our webhook code already handles Meta format, so the migration is smooth. This removes the Rs 0.42/message Twilio markup.
2. Migrate from SQLite to Supabase PostgreSQL — start with free tier, move to Pro (Rs 2,080/mo) when needed. This also gives us realtime sync for the Android app.
3. Add proper broadcast and template management features to our CRM dashboard.

About 11ZA and EaseByAI:

I would not commit to either right now. 11ZA's no-refund policy and number-lock are concerning. Their Rs 50K custom integration fee is also too much when we already have a working CRM. EaseByAI seems promising (AI chatbot, demo available) but we need to see their actual pricing first. I suggest we request a demo from EaseByAI and get their detailed pricing — if their platform fee is under Rs 1,000/month and they do not charge per-message markup on top of Meta, they could be worth considering later.

7. Demo & Trial Availability

Provider	Free Trial / Demo	How Fast	Details
Direct Meta	Self-service	N/A	Sign up at business.facebook.com. No demo needed.
Twilio	Free sandbox + \$15 credit	Instant	Can test immediately with sandbox number. No commitment.
11ZA	Not mentioned in quote	Unknown	Need to ask specifically. They did not offer a demo.
EaseByAI	Yes — offered demo	Reply to their WhatsApp	They proactively offered a quick demo. Just reply.
Supabase	Free tier (2 projects)	Instant	Create account, get 500 MB DB immediately.
Firebase	Free Spark plan	Instant	Google account signup. Generous free tier.
MongoDB Atlas	Free M0 cluster	Instant	5 GB free storage. Shared cluster. Good for testing.

Prepared by Sanchit Jha for Loopify internal team review. May 2026.
All prices are based on public pricing pages and quotes received. Costs may vary.